communication, but to all human transactions in secular daily life as well. Language itself is actually nothing else than a symbol for something higher—for thought. To be sure, individual words also arouse a typical interest in themselves, but viewed more closely, a word is just a series of letters; its meaning lies fundamentally in the concept which it expresses. And it is basically of a secondary importance whether the concept is represented by one word rather than by another, in one particular language rather than another. If the word is translated into another language, the concept itself remains unaffected.

Another example: A flag is the symbol of the glory and honor of a regiment of soldiers. The older the flag, the higher its value. In the heat of the battle, the bearer of the flag considers it to be his supreme duty not to desert the honored emblem at any cost, to protect it with his own body if need be, even to give his life for it if he must. Yet, a flag is just a symbol, a piece of a bright-colored cloth. The enemy can capture it, soil, mutilate it, but can never destroy the higher concept, of which it is the symbol. The regiment will still retain its honor, get a new flag, and perhaps exact suitable retribution for the insult to its emblem.

Just as in an army—and more generally in every community of men facing great tasks together—religion also finds symbols and their corresponding ecclesiastical rituals absolutely indispensable. They signify the highest and most venerated of all the products of human imagination directed heavenward. But we must never forget that even the most sacred symbol is of human origin.

Had mankind taken this truth to heart at all times, it would have been spared an infinity of woe and suffering. For the terrible religious wars, the horrible persecutions of heretics and their attendant tragic consequences, are in the last analysis the outcome of conflicts between opposing propositions, each possessing a certain validity and each originating in the circumstances that a common abstract idea, such as the belief in an omnipotent God, was confused with its visible but distinct media of expression, such as ecclesiastic articles of faith. Certainly there is nothing more distressing than the bitter fight of two adversaries, each of whom is fully convinced of the rightness of his cause and is filled with honest enthusiasm for it, feeling that he must devote all his energy to the battle, even sacrifice his life in it. How much productive work could have been accomplished if in the domain of religious activity such valuable energies had been united instead of employed for mutual extermination.

The deeply religious individual who gives expression to his belief in God through a veneration of his beloved sacred symbols, does not insist on them blindly, but has an understanding for the fact that there can be other persons as deeply religious as himself to whom other symbols are no less beloved and